

# Titian

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**T**he leading Venetian painter of the 16th century, Tiziano Vecelli, or Titian (c.1489–1576), became the official painter of the Venetian Republic in 1516. Renowned for powerful portraits conveying sitters' personalities, he also painted religious and mythological works filled with exuberant energy and sumptuous colour. Bellini's influence can be seen in his radiant palette and balanced compositions, while Giorgione inspired his early style.

Titian's paint application and use of colour had a huge influence on younger artists. Although his style changed during a long career, his unprecedented loose brushwork and subtlety of tonal contrast endured. In great demand, he also worked for the Dukes of Ferrara, Mantua and Urbino. After meeting the Holy Roman Emperor Charles V in Bologna in 1530, he became principal painter to the imperial court, and later to Charles's son, Philip II of Spain. From the late 1550s, Titian applied freer brushwork and fewer details, and by the late 1560s, his loose style appeared to be moving towards abstraction.



Titian, *Bacchus and Ariadne*, 1520–3